

OUR PATH

• Start

◦ Mindset

◦ Brief → spec

◦ Build

◦ Test & repair

◦ Take it home

Building Your Own Editing Workflows Using Claude Code.

Stop chatting with Claude and start standing up systems for your own craft. One worked example: a two-hour workshop recording cut into eleven vertical shorts inside Premiere Pro, with Claude driving the timeline, a scripted pipeline doing the repetition, and every decision's evidence left on disk.



Your guide today

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Tyler Sztuka

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SZD Labs is an applied AI implementation and upskilling firm focused on:

- Non-technical domain expert upskilling
- Anthropic platform implementation
- AI-augmented SDLC
- Enterprise AI token spend and performance optimization

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Over a decade in media production.

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Studio and social

Over a decade of professional media production. In college I ran a photography studio. I've done a lot of organic social media content creation.

The agency

Most recently I ran a creative agency: short-form to medium- and long-form market penetration for folks who had a presence on short-form and wanted to jump into YouTube. Full production, pre and post, a full in-house content studio. Filming, editing, scripting, everything.

The channel

A personal YouTube channel I grew to over 5,000 subscribers. Monetized, with sponsors.

My business today is fundamentally different, outside the creative industries, and I still do a lot of content creation and production for my personal brand and for the business. At least a decade of Adobe Creative Cloud: Photoshop, Lightroom, Premiere, After Effects, InDesign, Dreamweaver, Illustrator.



Open the workshop.

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SLIDES



SCAN FOR THE SLIDES

maxymeanderings.github.io/claude-for-creatives

This deck, with the recorded run and speaker notes.

SOURCE



SCAN FOR THE SOURCE

github.com/MaxyMeanderings/claude-for-creatives

The spec, the brief, the retro, yesterday's coach spec, and this deck. The six-step loop is one QR back. Copy it.

Type either one now. The spec, the brief, the retro, and these slides live there. You will want them tonight.



Copilot vs autopilot: own the cut.

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Copilot · stay engaged

Frame the edit and state your taste out loud.

Ask AI for options, explanations, and challenges.

Look at the frame. Explain why you accept or change the result.

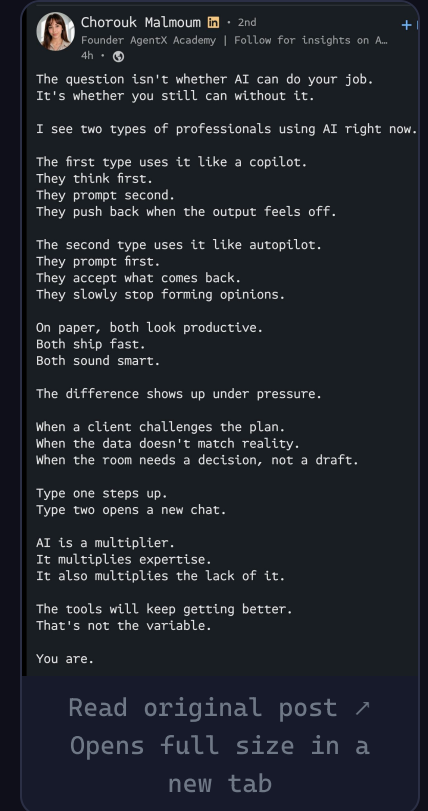
Autopilot · the trap

Hand over the framing before you know what you want.

Accept “ok” from a tool without looking at a frame.

Struggle to explain the cut when a client challenges it.

Before you export: can you explain the cut, show the frame, and name what would change your mind?



The tools we're using today.

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Claude Code

Runs the loop. Reads the folder, writes the files, drives the bridge.



Premiere Pro MCP server

The bridge. About 367 tools that let Claude Code talk to a running Premiere.



Adobe Premiere Pro

Where the edit lives. Same project, same timeline, same exports.

Three things. No plugin store, no new app, nothing you have to leave Premiere for.



Hiring an editor, not outsourcing the edit.

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MY LEAST FAVORITE PART OF ANY PRODUCTION

The rough cut. Clips into the timeline, sequencing everything together. Razor tool, razor tool, razor tool. What you learn through that is what a good edit looks like, when and where to cut, and how the audio and visual elements flow together.

Augment, not replace

We are using AI to augment the editing production cycle. We are still in the driver's seat. What we're doing is offloading the rote, tedious editing work.

Domain experience is still required

You can't do this without understanding editing, cinematography, and what good actually looks like.

The judgment stays yours

That creative discernment is something the AI is really not good at. You still need those priors, and they get wrapped into the spec and the evals as we build: your edits, your audience, your platforms.

This is not creative outsourcing. This is hiring an editor.



This is not cheap. And it is not the optimal setup.

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Not cheap

100,000+

tokens per edit, on average, with Opus

Having the AI go through and edit clips in the timeline, even in this refined state, is expensive. At API rates, that's expensive. That's why the refinement loops matter: they save you on cost.

Not optimal

This setup is not optimal for this. Claude Code, a harness designed for coding, talking through an MCP server to a legacy editing platform, is probably the least optimal AI editing arrangement I can think of.

Again, that's beside the point.

That is why these refinement loops are important. The setup is beside the point.



What we're building.

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The thing

A shorts pipeline: five small scripts and one job file that drive Premiere Pro through its MCP bridge. Claude Code runs it from a folder. No plugin store, no new app.

Its purpose

Turn a long recording into publishable vertical clips without clicking through the same ten steps eleven times. Selection stays human. Repetition goes to the script.

Who it's for

A creator or editor who owns the edit: you pick the moments, set the look, and judge every frame. No coding background to run it. Some to change it.

The outcome

Eleven 9:16 shorts from one recording: dead air cut, graded to match, framed on the speaker, captioned, exported. Plus a job file that runs the next one.



The eleven exports · Videos/C0828 Shorts · Sept 10, 2026 · one frame from each, three seconds in



One worked example. Your loop.

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Specify

Turn a one-page brief into observable requirements: what a cut is, what a good frame is, what done looks like. Nothing gets built yet.

Implement

Claude Code creates the scripts and the job file from the approved spec. You inspect what changed.

Demonstrate

Run it on one clip, look at the frame, repair a failure, and explain the evidence.

The example is a shorts pipeline, the smallest thing that still needs a spec and tests. The same loop builds a caption pass, a color match, a photo cull. The loop is what you leave with.



Build it in six visible steps.

Brief → Spec → Approve → Implement → Challenge → Repair

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Input

A one-page brief:
which recording, what
a clip is, what must
never be cut or
invented.

Files

A spec, a job file,
five scripts, and a
list of clips to pilot
before any batch.

Evidence

Frames captured from
the timeline, compared
with each requirement.

Swap the brief for your own edit. The six steps do not change.



Start with a behavior brief.

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BUILD-BRIEF.MD · THE INPUT

Cut a two-hour workshop recording into eleven vertical shorts inside Premiere Pro, for a solo creator who does their own editing. Selection stays human; the repetition does not.

- Remove dead air, keep every laugh and reaction. A pause is dead only when the transcript and the audio both say so.
- Match the grade on every clip to the master. Carry values, not copies.
- Frame the speaker in 9:16 without wobble. Never trust a crop you have not looked at.
- Captions from the transcript, remapped through the cuts. Editable, not burned.
- Export all eleven from one job file. The next recording is a new job file, not a new conversation.



What a conversation looks like.

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ME · RECORDED · SEPT 10, 2026, 11:40 PM

“yep, do those, also have it track me as I walk”

CLAUDE CODE · RECORDED RESPONSE EXCERPTS · SEPT 11, 12:25 AM

“9:16 with tracking – but not Adobe’s. Auto Reframe turned out to be useless on this footage: it locked onto the foreground audience and the slide screen instead of you, and it never punches in (I verified with frame captures before scrapping it).”

“Each segment gets a 1.7x punch-in framed on your measured position, with reframes landing exactly on the cuts, which is cleaner than a drifting auto-crop.”



Ask for a spec before code.

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TYPE IN CLAUDE CODE · IN YOUR FOLDER

Read BUILD-BRIEF.md and LESSONS.md. Draft SPEC.md; do not implement yet. Number requirements, exclusions, and acceptance clips. Map each requirement to a script, a phase, and the frame that proves it. Ask about consequential gaps. Wait for our approval.

This is the short form. The full Specify prompt, with the quality bar it must assess, is in [coach/BUILD-STEPS.md](#) ↗ in the loop repo. Next slide.

Which requirement would you try to break? Hold that thought. We run the one most editors pick: the crop.



Where the spec comes from.

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The brief · what it must do

BUILD-BRIEF.md, one page. Every rule the pipeline enforces, from “keep the laugh” to “one job file per recording,” traces back to a line in it.

The retro · what run one taught

LESSONS.md, written the night run one shipped. Seven process lessons and six domain findings, each with the cost it carried: Auto Reframe, the clipboard, the normalized coordinates, the wiped scratchpad.

Its questions · what you decide

The numbers only you can set: the quiet threshold for this room, the punch-in scale, where the slide screen sits, words per caption cue. Answered once in the job file. Changing one is a new run, not a new build.

Rhythm

applies · a cut keeps about 0.6 s of pause

LESSONS.md · dead air

Reactions

applies · gap ≥ 1.2 s and room tone, never level alone

LESSONS.md · dead air

Grade

by value · nine numbers read once, written to every clip

LESSONS.md · grade travels by value

Framing

no wobble · static per segment, reframes on the cuts

LESSONS.md · speakers walk during silences

Captions

editable · caption tracks plus sidecar SRTs; burn is taste

LESSONS.md · captions

The brief is yours. So is the bar: yesterday’s room used DRY and SOLID; an editor’s bar is rhythm, reactions, grade, framing, captions. The builder asks about the rest.



Review and approve the contract.

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REVIEW THE SPEC

Whose edit is this, and what stays human?
What counts as dead air, a matching grade, a good frame?
What must it never do without a frame to prove it?
Which clip would expose a failure?

TYPE IN CLAUDE CODE

Approved: implement only the requirements in SPEC.md.
First list the scripts you will write and the phase each one owns.
Pilot on the shortest clip before any batch.



Watch the files take shape.

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MY BUILD · PREMIERE-OPS · SEPT 11

```
CLAUDE.md
LESSONS.md
pipeline/
  mcp-client.mjs
  dead-air.mjs
  track-speaker.mjs
  make-srts.mjs
  build-shorts.mjs
jobs/c0828/job.config.json
Videos/C0828 Shorts/
  cut-plan.json  framing-table.json
  srt/SF01.srt ... SF11.srt
  SF01 ... SF11 9x16.mp4
```

Inspect what changed

One driver talks to Premiere. Four scripts decide nothing; they compute cuts, positions, and cues from the transcript and the audio.

The job file is the only thing that changes between recordings.

The state files are the evidence. They live next to the exports, never in a scratch folder that gets wiped.



Read the instruction that matters.

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MY BUILD · CLAUDE.MD:41 · THE PILOT RULE · EXACT EXCERPT

Pilot rule: after verticals, capture_frame ONE sequence at 2-3 timestamps before trusting the batch. Same after captions.

LESSONS.MD · LESSON 2 · THE LINE THAT PAID FOR IT

“The tool returned ok” is not verification for anything visual.

Now design a run that tempts it to skip this.



Test behavior, not just the file.

INPUT · PICK ONE, OR BRING YOUR OWN

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“Cut the dead air out of SF09. There is a laugh in it.”

“Make SF11 vertical and keep me in frame.”

“Match every clip to the master grade.”

“Caption SF01. It has nine cuts in it.”

WHAT YOU LOOK FOR

The laugh survives. Only pauses the transcript and the audio both call dead are shortened, to about 0.6 s.

Frame 1, the midpoint, the last frame: the speaker, chest-up, no black. Not the audience, not the slide screen.

Nine Basic Correction values identical on all eleven, one Lumetri instance each. No paste.

Cue timings shift by exactly the removed seconds at each cut. Three words per cue.

Recorded Sept 9 to 11 on the real project. The next slides are the run: frames from the timeline, files from the job folder.



The dead-air pass.

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CUT-PLAN.JSON · SF01 AND SF09 · EXACT · VIDEOS/C0828 SHORTS

```
{"id":"SF01","name":"SF01 Ownership story","trimmedDur":100.9,
  "chunks":[[1763,1768.89],[1774.15,1780.5],[1781.28,1790.37],[1791.09,1798.63],
            [1799.47,1820.57],[1821.17,1840.76],[1842.76,1858.79],[1859.52,1864.34],
            [1865.58,1868.24],[1871.04,1879]]}
{"id":"SF09","name":"SF09 Not a professional dev","trimmedDur":87.6,
  "chunks":[[389,398.9],[399.7,438.95],[440.58,479]]}
```

SF01 loses fifteen seconds across nine cuts, including a six-second walking pause at 29:28. SF09 keeps its laugh: that gap read -24.1 dB, above the room's -26 threshold, so it stayed. Twenty-nine cuts, about forty seconds, across eleven clips.



The first crop. The tool said ok.

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Auto Reframe ran on all eleven sequences and returned ok on every one. Nobody had looked at a frame yet. This is what it saw: audience in front, a bright slide screen, the speaker at the edge.



Give the challenger the evidence.

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TYPE IN CLAUDE CODE · BEFORE ANY BATCH

Pilot the shortest clip. capture_frame it at the first cut, the midpoint, and the last frame. Save the frames next to the exports. For each requirement, say which frame proves it. Mark pass, fail, or unresolved. Do not assume the tool's ok is correct.

The challenger here is a frame. A frame is evidence the way a quoted response was yesterday. Look at one before you render ten.



The verdict: fail.

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LESSONS.MD · LESSON 2 AND THE DOMAIN FINDING · EXACT EXCERPTS · SEPT 11

Auto Reframe was run on all 11 sequences before looking at a single frame; all 11 analyses (plus 11 caption attaches to those sequences) were thrown away when frame 1 showed it tracking the audience.

Adobe Auto Reframe is saliency-based and untunable via API; on a wide room shot it locks onto foreground audience and the slide screen, and it never punches in.

Frame 1 of the pilot. Twenty-two operations discarded. The requirement said “keep me in frame”; the tool passed its own check and failed ours.



Repair one failure. Test again.

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FAILURE TO CATCH · THIS RUN

Me: “have it track me as I walk.”

Tool: ok. Frame: the audience.

Small repair

Replace the saliency tracker with a motion tracker that knows the room: exclude the ceiling and the audience rows, down-weight the slide screen, centroid of what moves is the speaker.

Recheck

Pilot the shortest clip first. Frame 1, midpoint, last. Then a clip that already passed the cut test.



Repair one rule.

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BEFORE · ONE TOOL CALL

```
auto_reframe_sequence("SF11 9x16")  
→ ok
```

AFTER · TRACK-SPEAKER.MJS · JOBS/C0828/JOB.CONFIG.JSON

```
weight = 0    above ceilingY 200  
weight = 0    below audienceY 1400  
weight = 0.12 inside screenRect  
                [1250, 420, 2550, 1200]  
centroid of motion per segment  
→ one static Motion Position  
→ reframes land on the cuts
```

One script replaces one tool call. The numbers are this room's, read off one extracted frame and written into the job file. Nothing else in the build changed.



Rerun the same clip.

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Source · C0828.MP4 · 1:55:55



SF11 9x16.mp4 · 0:04 · 1215x2160

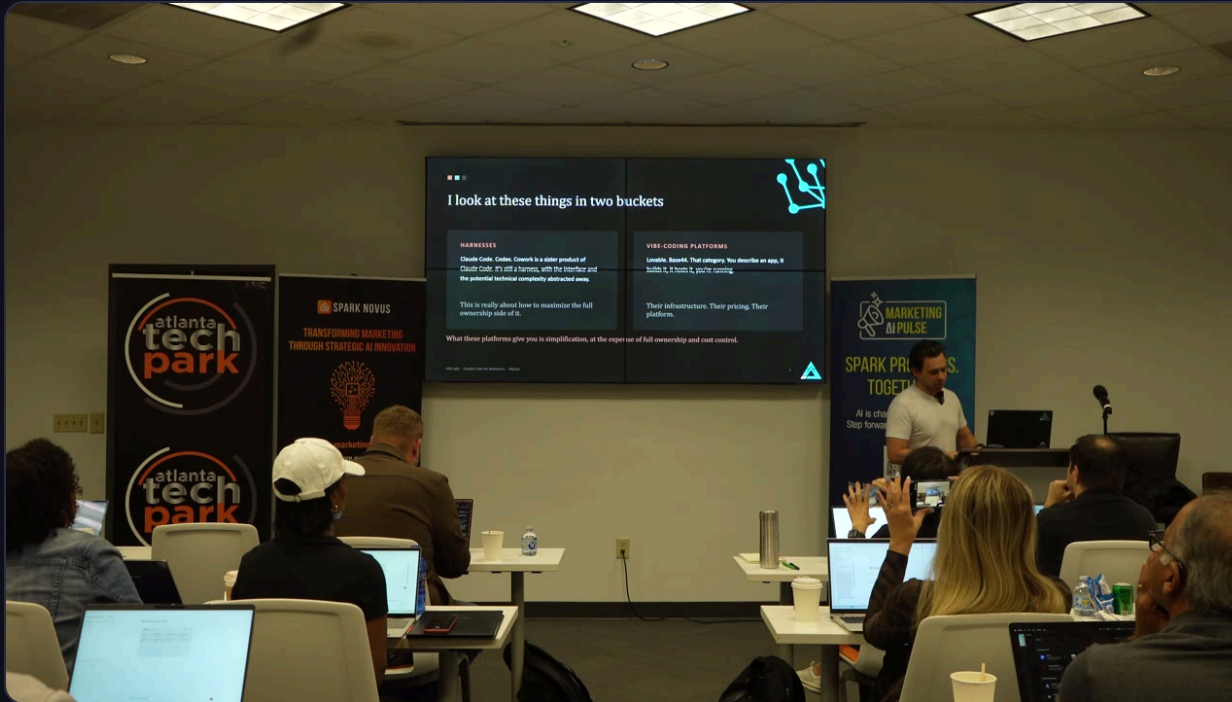
SF11, the shortest clip, piloted first. Left: the source. Right: the vertical export. Chest-up, the speaker, not the banner. Then the midpoint, the last frame, and only then the other ten.



Challenge it again. A smaller failure, a smaller repair.

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Source · C0828.MP4 · 29:35



SF01 9x16.mp4 · 0:12 · after the fix

The first pilot frame after the repair was black. Motion Position is normalized 0 to 1 through the API, not pixels as documented; pixel values put the media off-canvas. One line fixed it. Frame 1 caught it in one call; the batch would have exported eleven black videos.



Unresolved is a verdict too.

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CLAUDE.MD · THE GRADE PHASE · EXACT EXCERPT

grade exits 2 listing clips that need Lumetri added by hand (QE can't add effects), one UI drag per clip from the Effects panel, then rerun.

LESSONS.MD · LESSON 3 · EXACT EXCERPT

Two unexplained failures of the same approach = stop and run a decisive diagnostic, not variant #3. The Lumetri copy/paste saga burned half a session: four paste-attributes variants, a Premiere restart, a focus-stealing hunt.

The clipboard path died four ways in half a session. The repair was not a fifth variant. The pipeline names the clips it cannot grade and stops; you drag once per clip. The tool cannot, and the build says so instead of pretending.



What you just watched.

→ Which requirement did we pick?

→ Where does the pipeline enforce that behavior?

→ What clip did we run, and what did the frame show?

→ What did we repair, and what stays a human step?

A brief → a pipeline → frames as evidence. Now swap in your own edit.

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Write your own brief. One page.

OUR PATH

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✓ Build

✓ Test & repair

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YOUR-BRIEF.MD · FIVE LINES · ANY EDIT

- Who it helps, and the moment it helps them.
- What it must do, in behaviors you can see in a frame or a file.
- What it must never do: cut a reaction, invent a caption, export without a look.
- What it produces: the two or three outputs you would actually reuse.
- How you know it worked: three clips and the visible failure for each.

Then the same six steps

Put the brief in an empty folder. Start Claude Code. Ask for the spec. Approve it. Inspect the files. Run your three clips. Repair one thing.

A podcast-to-clips pass. A caption style you actually like. A color match across a shoot. A photo cull by your own rules. The loop is the same.

Your edit, not mine. Write the brief tonight.



Run the full loop tonight.

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Build your own

[Clone the loop repo ↗](#)

[Follow coach/BUILD-STEPS.md ↗](#)

[Start from YOUR-BRIEF.md ↗](#)

Save your spec, scripts, job file, pilot frames, and the clips you judged.



CLONE THE LOOP



BUILD-STEPS.MD



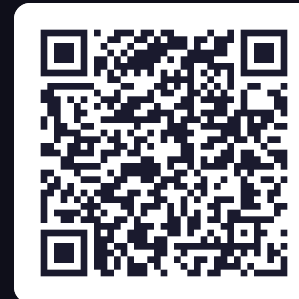
YOUR-BRIEF.MD

Compare and continue

[premiere-pro-mcp, the bridge into Premiere ↗](#)

[The coach: the same loop, yesterday ↗](#)

[These slides ↗](#)



PREMIERE-PRO-MCP



THE COACH EXAMPLE



THESE SLIDES

Any Claude Code account works. Premiere Pro 2025 and the free bridge if you want the editing half. Your brief, an empty folder, the same six steps.



Stay connected.

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LINKEDIN



SZDLABS.IO

Thanks for judging with me. The loop is in the repo. Copy it.



Keep building. Take the links.

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SLIDES



SCAN FOR THE SLIDES

maxymeanderings.github.io/claude-for-creatives

This deck, with the recorded run and speaker notes.

Slides and the loop. Type it or click it.

SOURCE



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github.com/MaxyMeanderings/claude-for-creatives

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